MELBOURNE, AUSTRALIA

National Gallery of Victoria: Masterpieces

From a broad river valley to a handful of coins, twenty works show how size and distance organise a picture.



Streeton's river bends through a view too broad for any one small incident to control. In Tucker's *Judas*, a cramped body, a wooden form and coins occupy almost all the available attention. Between those extremes, a garden can become a working place, a portrait can depend on the relative sizes of hands and head, and a battle can set an ordered formation against individual danger.

Scale here means more than a canvas's dimensions. It includes what a painter brings close, reduces, enlarges or leaves without a familiar measure. This selection follows those decisions across landscape, portraiture and narrative, ending with colour areas that offer no object against which to judge their extent.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/national-gallery-victoria

The selection · 20

1. The Purple Noon's Transparent Might
   Arthur Streeton · 1896
2. The House at Rueil
   Édouard Manet · 1882
3. Boulevard Montmartre, Morning, Grey Weather
   Camille Pissarro · 1897
4. Lion Attacking a Horse
   George Stubbs · 1765
5. Antaeus Setting Down Dante and Virgil
   William Blake · 1824-1827
6. Portrait of the Painter Manuel Humbert
   Amedeo Modigliani · 1916
7. An Old Bee Farm
   Clara Southern · 1900
8. Evensong
   Clara Southern · 1900-1914
9. Field Naturalists
   Jane Sutherland · 1896
10. The Mushroom Gatherers
    Jane Sutherland · 1895
11. Blue and Gold: Portrait of Dorothy Sutherland
    Jane Sutherland · 1908
12. Spring
    Arthur Streeton · 1890
13. Sydney Harbour
    Arthur Streeton · 1907
14. Winter Morning near Heidelberg
    Louis Buvelot · 1866
15. Summer Afternoon, Templestowe
    Louis Buvelot · 1866
16. The Apple Woman and Her Husband
    Mark Gertler · 1912
17. The 28th Regiment at Quatre Bras, 1815
    Elizabeth Thompson · 1875
18. Interior with Figures
    Gwen John · 1898-1899
19. Untitled (Red)
    Mark Rothko · 1956
20. Judas
    Albert Tucker · 1955

01 / 20

The Purple Noon's Transparent Might

Arthur Streeton

1896 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery of Victoria



Arthur Streeton. The purple noon’s transparent might. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Full source frame, proportional resize and JPEG compression. https://www.wikiart.org/en/arthur-streeton/the-purple-noon-s-transparent-might-1896 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Seen from above, the river gives the broad view a continuous bend to follow. Its nearer blue remains strong while distant hills and sky lose contrast. Streeton makes the apparent heat a relation between distances, rather than an added anecdote about the day. The changing clarity of the land carries the sensation across the whole prospect.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 33-2

02 / 20

The House at Rueil

Édouard Manet

1882 · National Gallery of Victoria



Édouard Manet. The House at Rueil. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The trunk interrupts the façade near its centre, preventing a complete architectural presentation. Pale walls and blue shutters remain readable through separate patches between tree and garden growth. Manet lets the obstruction organise attention instead of clearing it away. The house is encountered as something seen from a particular garden position, with parts necessarily withheld.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Boulevard Montmartre, Morning, Grey Weather

Camille Pissarro

1897 · National Gallery of Victoria



Camille Pissarro. Boulevard Montmartre Morning, Grey Weather. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Repeated marks turn pedestrians and carriages into a collective movement along the narrowing street. Buildings and bare trees supply the larger recession, while the grey distance reduces individual definition. Pissarro allows the city's traffic to remain many events at once. A figure need not acquire a separate story to contribute to the visible life of the boulevard.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Lion Attacking a Horse

George Stubbs

1765 · National Gallery of Victoria



George Stubbs. Lion Attacking a Horse. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The animals lock into a single struggle above the low landscape. The horse's stretched neck extends the effect of the lion's grip through its whole body. Stubbs uses anatomical articulation to make force understandable: the attack is registered by the victim's twisting response. Pale and dark masses distinguish the participants even where their positions become inseparable.

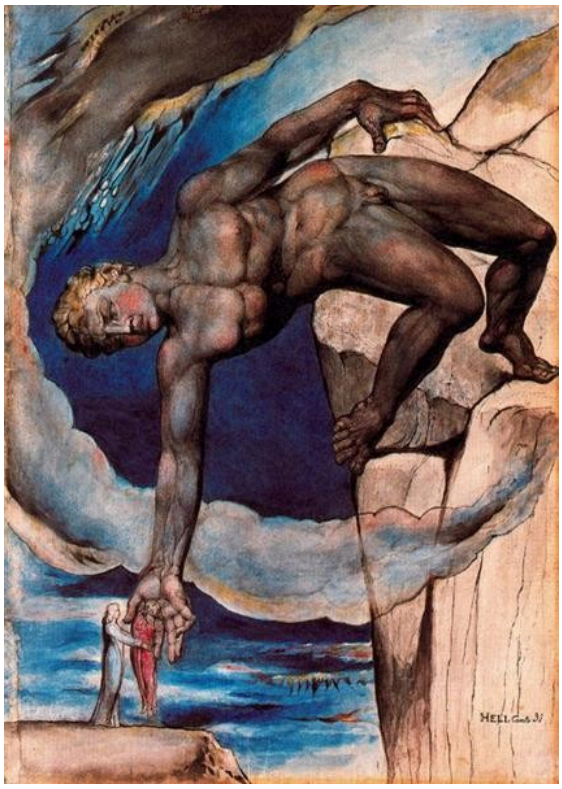
Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Antaeus Setting Down Dante and Virgil

William Blake

1824-1827 · National Gallery of Victoria



William Blake. Antaeus setting down Dante and Virgil in the last circle of hell. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The giant's bent body becomes the means by which the smaller poets move through the scene. Blake makes scale perform the narrative: a single figure can bridge a distance that would otherwise require a landscape route. Following his curve takes the eye toward the depths below, joining the act of looking to the act of being lowered.

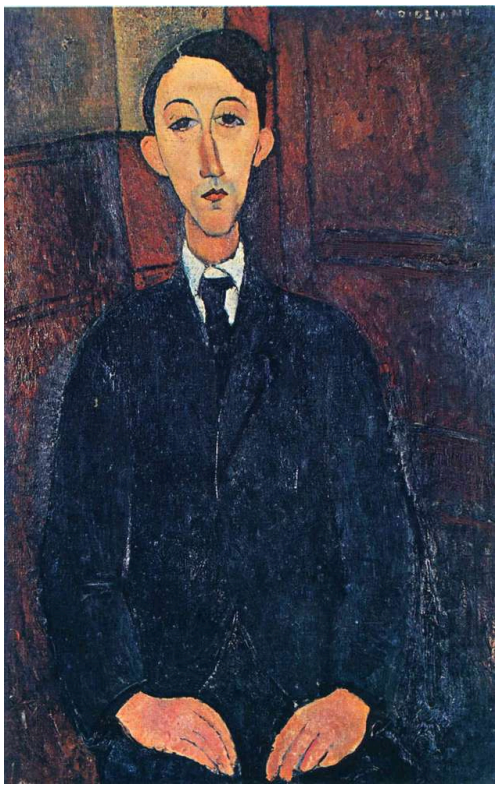
Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Portrait of the Painter Manuel Humbert

Amedeo Modigliani

1916 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery of Victoria



Amedeo Modigliani. Portrait of the painter Manuel Humbert. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/amedeo-modigliani/portrait-of-the-painter-manuel-humbert-1916-1 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Small warm hands counter the elongated head and neck above the dark suit. Modigliani changes bodily proportion without making posture irrelevant. The frontal presentation remains a seated person's arrangement, with compact gestures below and a stretched facial form above. The portrait's balance depends on keeping those unequal scales in relation rather than correcting them into anatomical uniformity.

Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

An Old Bee Farm

Clara Southern

1900 · National Gallery of Victoria



Clara Southern. An Old Bee Farm. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Hives identify the clearing as a place of work, but they remain embedded in grass and cool light. The figure's activity occupies one part of a setting that includes weathered objects and a small building. Southern gives the whole modest environment sustained attention. Human use is present without requiring a worker to dominate every other element.

Object source · Open artwork

08 / 20

Evensong

Clara Southern

1900-1914 · National Gallery of Victoria



Clara Southern. Evensong. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Violet and grey draw houses, sloping ground and valley into a narrowing tonal range. Evening is established across the view rather than announced by a spectacular sun. Southern makes reduced differences do the work of time. The landscape stays locatable while its parts begin to share the conditions of fading light.

Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

Field Naturalists

Jane Sutherland

1896 · National Gallery of Victoria



Jane Sutherland. Field Naturalists. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The people are small enough for plants around their feet to retain a substantial place in the image. The title identifies an attentive activity already compatible with that distribution of space. Sutherland places observers inside the landscape rather than outside it as its sole measure. Looking becomes one of the things happening among grasses and trees.

Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

The Mushroom Gatherers

Jane Sutherland

1895 · National Gallery of Victoria



Jane Sutherland. The Mushroom Gatherers. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

One body bends while another remains upright, dividing the search into different moments. Cut stumps interrupt the grassy ground where their attention is directed. The task changes what counts as landscape interest: the immediate surface matters as much as a distant view. Sutherland gives an ordinary act of gathering its own bodily and spatial demands.

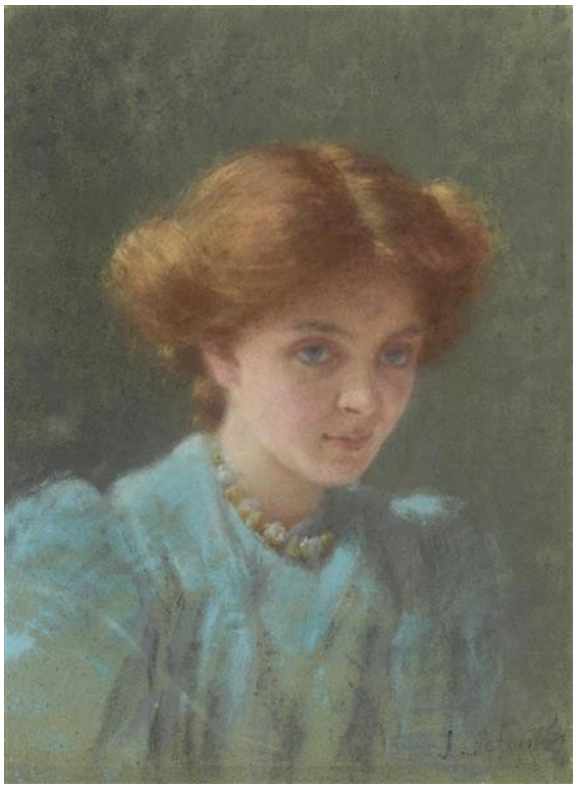
Object source · Open artwork

11 / 20

Blue and Gold: Portrait of Dorothy Sutherland

Jane Sutherland

1908 · National Gallery of Victoria



Jane Sutherland. Blue and Gold: Portrait of Dorothy Sutherland. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Copper-coloured hair and the blue garment establish the relation announced by the title. Within it, the face is more closely defined than the clothing below. Unequal finish guides attention without requiring a rigid contour around every feature. The sitter's likeness emerges from a colour arrangement whose loosest passages remain important to the whole.

Object source · Open artwork

12 / 20

Spring

Arthur Streeton

1890 · Oil on canvas on plywood · National Gallery of Victoria



Arthur Streeton. Spring. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Full source frame, proportional resize and JPEG compression. https://www.wikiart.org/en/arthur-streeton/spring-1890 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The narrow track draws the near ground into a field where flowering trees have room to register. Fresh green and blue sky establish the seasonal contrast without filling the view with incident. Streeton allows ordinary growth to be enough. The open area around it gives relatively small changes of colour and vegetation a larger pictorial consequence.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: A14-1978

13 / 20

Sydney Harbour

Arthur Streeton

1907 · Oil on canvas on plywood · National Gallery of Victoria



Arthur Streeton. Sydney Harbour. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Full source frame, proportional resize and JPEG compression. https://www.wikiart.org/en/arthur-streeton/sydney-harbour-1907 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Near branches keep the viewpoint attached to the shore, while vessels, buildings and headlands spread across the water beyond. That foreground interruption makes the harbour's breadth more apparent. Streeton balances a confined point of observation with an extensive prospect. The viewer occupies one place even when the eye can travel widely through the picture.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 491-2

14 / 20

Winter Morning near Heidelberg

Louis Buvelot

1866 · National Gallery of Victoria



Louis Buvelot. Winter morning near Heidelberg. Image credit: Louis Buvelot; Source credit: National Gallery of Victoria, Scan using old "Original & Fälschung"-Pictures from Hörzu 10/1988, S. 162. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Trees and their reflections form a dense central structure, opening toward brighter land behind. Buvelot uses the pool to extend the bank's dark forms rather than simply add a second view of them. Morning light must be followed through that enclosure. The picture's depth comes from a passage between masses as much as from a distant horizon.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: p.300.4-1

15 / 20

Summer Afternoon, Templestowe

Louis Buvelot

1866 · National Gallery of Victoria



Louis Buvelot. Summer afternoon, Templestowe. Image credit: Louis Buvelot (03 March 1814 - 30 May 1888) (Swiss) Born in Morges, Vaud, Switzerland. Died in Melbourne, Victoria. Details on Google Art Project; Source credit: twHB-7i_mIcVaA at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Sky and dry ground share warm colours, reducing the contrast between them. A track, thin trees and fence supply enough structure to keep that continuity from becoming vague. Buvelot lets afternoon light spread across the view with few strong interruptions. The small incidents remain subordinate to the repeated conditions affecting the whole scene.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: p.300.5-1

16 / 20

The Apple Woman and Her Husband

Mark Gertler

1912 · National Gallery of Victoria



Mark Gertler. The apple woman and her husband. Image credit: Mark Gertler (09 December 1891 - 23 June 1939) (English) Born in Spitalfields, London, England. Died in Highgate, London, England. Details on Google Art Project; Source credit: 1AGFb1dEzkOQqw at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The woman sits before her husband in compressed space, with apples gathered at the edge of their closely arranged bodies. Firm outlines give the pair solidity. Against those weighty forms, the red spotted scarf introduces a quicker decorative rhythm. Gertler lets a pattern enliven the group without weakening its almost crowded bodily presence.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 3002-4

17 / 20

The 28th Regiment at Quatre Bras, 1815

Elizabeth Thompson

1875 · National Gallery of Victoria



Elizabeth Thompson. The 28th Regiment at Quatre Bras, 1815. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The infantry's held formation confronts the disorder of horses and figures pressing through the foreground. Smoke conceals parts of the action farther away. Thompson makes military order something maintained under visible pressure, rather than a static arrangement. The line of soldiers gives the individual dangers a collective measure, while the surrounding movement tests its apparent stability.

Object source · Open artwork

18 / 20

Interior with Figures

Gwen John

1898-1899 · National Gallery of Victoria



Gwen John. Interior with Figures. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Pale and warmer clothing distinguish two women standing close in a dim, furnished room. Small differences of turn carry the encounter, with patterned walls and furniture leaving little spare space around them. Gwen John does not need to specify a dramatic exchange. Proximity and restrained movement already give the interior a particular human arrangement.

Object source · Open artwork

19 / 20

Untitled (Red)

Mark Rothko

1956 · Oil · National Gallery of Victoria



Mark Rothko. Untitled (Red). WikiArt source label: Mark Rothko Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/mark-rothko/untitled-red-1956 · Mark Rothko Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

No horizon or recognisable object fixes the scale of these red and orange areas. Attention moves instead toward their soft, uneven contacts and the slight differences within colour. Rothko's boundaries remain active because they resist becoming ruled divisions. Spending time with an edge reveals change that a quick inventory of the picture's colours would miss.

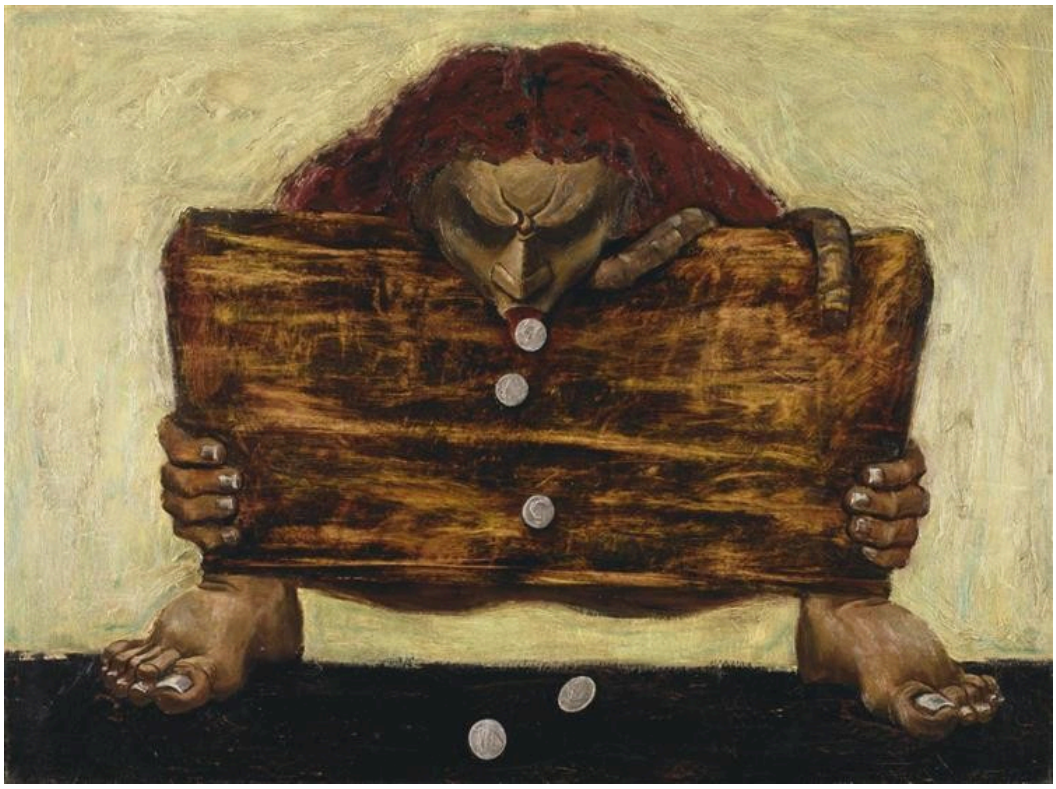
Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

Judas

Albert Tucker

1955 · National Gallery of Victoria



Albert Tucker. Judas. Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

The crouched body presses against the available space, gripping a broad wooden form above pale coins. Tucker condenses the biblical subject into a few materially forceful elements. The lowered head and cramped extremities make burden a physical relation before it becomes an ethical reading. Money remains plainly visible within the arrangement rather than being left as background information.

Object source · Open artwork

Change the distance of your attention

A river bend and the edge of a red field ask for different kinds of looking. Give each the scale its argument needs, then compare what disappears when attention moves too quickly. These are collection selections, not promises of a particular hanging; confirm current access through the NGV before planning around an individual work.

Further reading

The Elements of Drawing

John Ruskin · Read free · English

The Elements of Drawing asks readers to study the structure of trees, clouds and shadows closely. It supplies practical questions for looking at Southern, Sutherland and Streeton, without pretending to describe their intentions.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

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